

The Inspection Playbook

The staff side of an Ofsted inspection, in plain English.

On the staff side, inspectors ask for the same records almost every time, and every one of them can be ready before the notice arrives.

This playbook goes through eleven staff-side records the inspection framework says inspectors examine, with the regulation behind each: what they ask for, what good looks like, what fails, and what to fix this week. Then two scripts, for the employment gap conversation and the reference call. Then how to run your own mock inspection in an hour. Inspections follow their own lines of enquiry, so treat this as the floor.

It pairs with the free workbook, which does the counting for you: the Annex A staffing answers Ofsted asks for on notice of inspection, worked out from your staff list; the training matrix where every date you type gets its expiry computed and coloured beside it; the supervision tracker, the DBS re-check log and the governance clocks.

Nothing here is legal advice. Where a line says what the law requires, the regulation is named; where it is good practice, it says so.

The eleven records, one by one

1. Statement of purpose (regulation 16)

The document that describes what your home is for and how it is staffed.

Good looks like: reviewed in the last year, matches how the home actually runs, staffing section is current.

What fails:

written three managers ago. Says things the home no longer does.

Fix this week: read it end to end. Mark every sentence that is no longer true. That is your revision list.

2. Staff list with qualifications (regulation 32; Annex A Section 7)

Who works here, what they hold, and what they are working towards.

Good looks like: one page, current, and it can answer the Annex A staffing questions without a recount.

What fails:

a payroll export with no qualifications on it.

Fix this week: fill in the Staff list tab in the workbook. Anyone whose Status reads "Date passed, not started" needs a plan today.

3. Recruitment and vetting records (regulation 32; Schedule 2)

The six Schedule 2 items for every person: identity, DBS, references, why earlier work with children ended, qualifications, employment history with gaps explained.

Good looks like: every file complete, and you know it is complete because someone checked it against the list.

What fails:

a gap in a work history with no satisfactory explanation recorded.

Fix this week: run the Staff file checklist tab against two files, say your longest-serving person and your newest.

4. Training records (regulation 33)

Mandatory courses in date for everyone, with the expiry dates known, not guessed.

Good looks like: a matrix where the expiry dates compute themselves and someone looks every Monday.

What fails:

dates in someone's head. A first aid certificate that quietly ran out in March.

Fix this week: move your dates into the Training matrix. Fix the first red Expires cell.

5. Supervision records (regulation 33(4))

Regular, effective, recorded. Including the manager's own supervision.

Good looks like: on the cycle your statement of purpose promises, showing real conversations with agreed actions.

What fails:

gaps in the cycle. Records that are a date and two signatures. No record for the manager.

Fix this week: fill the Supervision tracker tab. If the manager's row is red, fix that one first.

6. Staffing rotas (regulation 31)

The rota as planned, and evidence of what actually happened when reality diverged.

Good looks like: published rotas, corrected when swaps happen, with cover levels and a first aider on every shift.

What fails:

a rota that says one thing while everyone knows the month went differently.

Fix this week: check last month's rota against what really happened. Correct it. That correction is the record.

7. Allegations records (regulation 12; Working Together)

Held securely, with the timescales evidenced: reported to a senior manager immediately, the designated officer told within one working day.

Good looks like: a locked record showing dates for every step, however uncomfortable the content.

What fails:

an allegation everyone remembers but nobody wrote down at the time.

Fix this week: check the last allegation record shows its dates. If there has never been one, check the team knows the reporting steps cold.

8. Regulation 44 reports (regulation 44)

The independent visitor, every month, and what happened to the actions they raised.

Good looks like: a full run of months, each report filed, each action closed and traceable.

What fails:

a missing month. Actions raised in March still open in August with no note why.

Fix this week: fill the visit grid on the Governance clocks tab. A missed month is a breach; know before they do.

9. Regulation 45 review (regulation 45)

Your own six-month review of the quality of care, sent to Ofsted within 28 days of completion.

Good looks like: built from the home's own records, honest about weaknesses, with actions that then actually happened.

What fails:

overdue, or glowing in a way your own records contradict.

Fix this week: find the date of your last one. Add six months. Put the deadline in the diary.

10. Notifications (regulation 40)

The serious events you told Ofsted about. Ofsted's guidance: a child's death immediately; everything else without delay and, where possible, within 24 hours. With who else was told and what was done.

Good looks like: a log that matches reality: every notifiable event, notified, with the follow-up recorded.

What fails:

an event in the daily logs that never became a notification.

Fix this week: agree with your team, in one sentence each, what counts as notifiable. Ambiguity is where these get missed.

11. Location assessment (regulation 46)

The annual review of whether the home's location keeps children safe.

Good looks like: reviewed within the year, involving the local police and authority view, with the risks named and managed.

What fails:

three years old, or missing the thing everyone locally knows about.

Fix this week: check the date on yours. Put its renewal on the Governance clocks tab.

Script one: the employment gap conversation

Schedule 2 asks for a full employment history with a satisfactory written explanation of any gap. You have found one. Here is the conversation. It takes two minutes and it is not an accusation.

"While I was checking the files I noticed a gap in your work history, between [month] and [month]. I need to record what that period was, in your words. What were you doing then?"

Write what they say, in their words, date it, and put it in the file. If they are not sure of the dates, record that they are not sure and what they can remember. If their account does not fit the rest of the history, ask again and follow it up; that is what "satisfactory" means. Never write an explanation for them.

The record is their account and your judgment of it, not a sentence for the sake of a sentence.

Script two: the reference verification call

Schedule 2 requires two written references, one from the most recent employer. Verifying them by phone is good practice, not a rule, and it is what turns a letter into something you have checked. Ring the organisation's main number, not the mobile on the letter, and ask for the person who signed it.

"Hello, I'm [name], manager at a children's home. [Person] has applied to work with us and gave us a reference in your name. Can I take two minutes to confirm it? Did you write it? Can you confirm the dates they worked with you, and their role? Why did they leave? And the one I have to ask: would you employ them again, in work around children?"

Then two lines on paper: who you spoke to, when, and what they confirmed. Date it, initial it, staple it to the reference. That note is your record of the check.

If the referee hesitates on the last question, that hesitation is the most useful thing the call could have given you. Follow it.

Run your own mock inspection in an hour

Book one uninterrupted hour. Bring the self-audit sheet from the pack and go through it the way an inspector would: for each item, the document itself, not a description of it.

First ten minutes: the eleven items. For each one, actually fetch the thing. Not "we have that" but the document, on the table. Grade it Ready, Question or Gap while it is in your hand.

Next twenty minutes: two staff files, for example your longest-serving person and your newest starter. Run the Staff file checklist against both. The long-server tests your history; the starter tests your process.

Next twenty minutes: follow one thread all the way down. Pick last month's regulation 44 report, take one action from it, and trace it: who owned it, when it closed, where the evidence lives. Inspectors follow one action through in the same way.

Last ten minutes: write the list. Every Gap gets a name and a date. Every Question gets a sentence about what would make it Ready. Put the list where the team sees it.

Do this once a quarter. By the third time, the list is short.

Annex A: the staffing numbers, answered before they ask

When Ofsted gives notice of a full inspection, the registered manager fills in Annex A, the request for information. Section 7 is staffing, and it wants numbers: the manager's level 5 (28.1 to 28.3), new care staff since the last full inspection (29) and leavers (30), how many TIMES agency staff were used and how many DIFFERENT agency people (30.1, 30.2), permanent and agency care staff and how many part time (31, 32), who holds the level 3 (33), who is past the regulation 32 relevant date and of those who is qualified or still working on it (34), and valid first aid (35). Vacancies (SV1), healthcare training (H3) and the dates of the statement of purpose and location assessment (39, 41) sit elsewhere on the same form.

Most homes count these by hand on the day. The workbook does it from two tabs you keep anyway: the Staff list (one row per person, leavers included) and the Agency shifts log (one line per cover shift). Type the date of your last full inspection at the top of the Annex A tab and every answer fills in under the form's number, with a note of where it came from.

Three things the workbook keeps straight

Two dates per person. When someone joined this home drives new starters and leavers. When they first

worked in a care role, anywhere, drives the regulation 32 clock for the level 3. One date cannot do both jobs.

Two agency counts. Times means shifts: the same person on ten nights is ten. Different members means people: that same person is one. Spell each name the same way every time.

A counting date. Every count runs from the last full inspection up to today, or a date you type, so a shift, start or leaving date in the future is not counted.

On the level 3 clock: regulation 32(5) puts the relevant date two years after first starting in a care role, and 32(6) lets the registered person defer it for part-time work or a prolonged absence. That deferral is a decision to record, not automatic, so the Staff list has a column for it. For the 34.1 count, the form's own guidance suggests counting part-time staff only after five years; the workbook follows the form for the count and the regulation for each person's Status.

The question numbers are the form's as updated 1 April 2026. Always check the wording against the copy Ofsted sends you.

The new law, in plain English

The Children's Wellbeing and Schools Act 2026 received Royal Assent on 29 April 2026. The headlines were about the biggest providers. The practical changes for a home's paperwork are quieter and worth knowing.

There is more financial oversight, especially of larger providers. There is more attention on provider groups as a whole, not just single homes. And there is a clear direction of travel: be able to show where the money goes and how the home is run, because the asking is going to increase.

This is commentary on where the Act points, not a list of current duties; the detail comes through regulations and guidance over time. For staff records the likely direction is three things: workforce numbers, turnover and agency use looked at rather than assumed; spending on quality and safety the spending that survives scrutiny; and records that can be produced quickly and completely as the mark of a well-run home.

None of this is frightening for a home whose files are straight. All of it is a reason to straighten them this quarter rather than next.

The pack, and one honest line

The workbook next to this playbook holds ten working tabs: the Annex A staffing answers, the staff list with its regulation 32 status, the agency shift log, the training matrix and its automatic expiries, the supervision tracker, the DBS re-check log, the governance clocks with the visit grid, the staff file checklist, the employment gap worksheet, and the self-audit.

Everything is free because every home needs this and most homes are too busy to build it. Made by Staffbook. Use it, copy it, hand it to the home down the road.

That is the whole pack. Check the dates once a week and the rest looks after itself.